Morbid in MTG: Rules, History, and Best Cards

Pedro Furtado (djorso) / December 4, 2024 / MTG Cards, MTG Rules

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MORBID
Rules, FAQ, and Top Cards
MTG Rules

Deathreap Ritual | *Illustration by Steve Argyle*

In revisiting the huge success that was the original *Innistrad* block, there's no way we're not talking about one of the key mechanics: morbid. It's such a flavor win in a set that's mainly about horror. Is anyone ever safe?

Sometimes you'll kill or block your opponent's creature and be punished with a big morbid creature coming your way, or you won't be sure if you should attack into them because morbid will punish you (or sometimes you're the one using that to your advantage).

Golgari (●●) decks often have an element of fear and surprise, so what better way to display that than to take advantage of creature deaths? Today I'm talking morbid rules interactions, best cards, and a fun EDH deck to showcase the mechanic. Let's go!

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How Does Morbid Work?

Tragic Slip | *Illustration by Christopher Moeller*

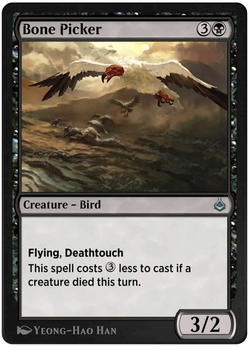
Morbid is an ability word that checks to see if a creature died during a given turn. It doesn't matter who controls the creature or who's turn it is. This can happen in a combat situation, by creature death via combat, removal spells, or sacrifice effects. Morbid-heavy decks usually have many ways for this to happen, including sacrifice outlets and black "kill spells." So why is it any good? Morbid creatures and spells are extra powerful if the death trigger is activate. More specifically, you usually want to cast the morbid spells *after* a creature dies to reap the benefits.

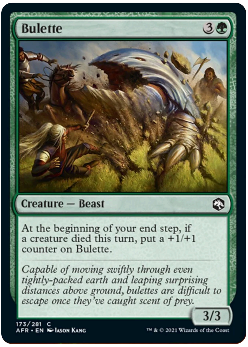
For example, Tragic Slip gives a creature -13/-13 instead of -1/-1, while Festerhide Boar enters the battlefield with two extra +1/+1 counters to make it a formidable 5/5. There's a subset of morbid cards like Deathreap Ritual and Reaper from the Abyss that care about morbid once per turn.

Morbid can be found on any spell or permanent type. We've more recently seen the concept expanded with a mana rock that gets stronger with morbid triggers (Séance Board), and even an *Unfinity* sticker card that grants the mechanic.

The History of Morbid in MTG

Morbid debuted in the original *Innistrad* set in 2011. The mechanic was centered in green/black, the two colors that care about life, the graveyard, and related stuff, with a red Brimstone Volley to boot.


Bone Picker
3
Creature – Bird
Flying, Deathtouch
This spell costs ③ less to cast if a creature died this turn.
3/2
Yeong-Hao Han


Bulette
3
Creature — Beast
At the beginning of your end step, if a creature died this turn, put a +1/+1 counter on Bulette.
Capable of moving swiftly through even tightly-packed earth and leaping surprising distances above ground, bulettes are difficult to escape once they've caught scent of prey.
3/3
173/281 C
AFR • EN Jason Kang
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Morbid returned several times in sets like *Dark Ascension*, *Commander 2014*, and *Modern Horizons*. Adding new morbid cards to *Foundations* shows that WotC really considers the mechanic flavorful and worth revisiting. There's also "pseudo-morbid," cards that care if a creature died but without the mechanic keyword. Cards like Bone Picker from *Amonkhet* and Bulette from *Forgotten Realms* are examples. As a matter of fact, the green/black morbid theme has been in a few sets (M21, AFR), but without using the morbid mechanic per se.

If we consider pseudo-morbid, the first card with the mechanic was Osai Vultures, a white creature from *Legends*. Morbid and pseudo-morbid are never a downside, but it has already appeared as a restrictive way of casting a spell (Grim Wanderer can be only cast *if* a creature died this turn).

What if the Creature that Died Is Removed from the Graveyard?

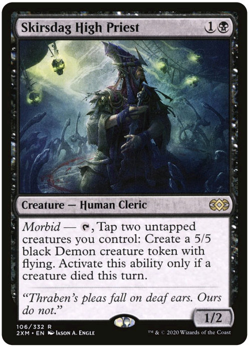
If the creature dies and goes to the graveyard, morbid triggers regardless of whether it's removed from the graveyard afterwards. You can exile the creature from the graveyard or bring it back to your hand, library, or battlefield, but the morbid trigger only cares about a creature hitting the graveyard.

Morbid can be negated if an effect prevents the creature from going to the graveyard. For example, Anafenza, the Foremost that says that if a creature would die, exile it instead. This Anafenza doesn't allow morbid to trigger because the exile effect overrides the death effect (creature tokens are excluded in this example). It also negates creatures that have death triggers, like "when (card) dies, draw a card and lose 1 life.”

How Does Morbid Work with Token Creatures?

Morbid doesn’t care if the creature that died is a token creature or a nontoken creature. This helps decks with token producers enable the morbid mechanic easier by sacrificing tokens instead of creatures.

How Do Activated Morbid Abilities Work?


Skirsdag High Priest
1
Creature — Human Cleric
Morbid — ⟳, Tap two untapped creatures you control: Create a 5/5 black Demon creature token with flying. Activate this ability only if a creature died this turn.
“Thraben’s pleas fall on deaf ears. Ours do not.”
1/2
106/332 R
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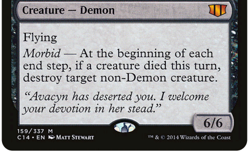
A morbid activated ability checks to see if morbid is “online” before the ability can be activated. It's a sort of checkbox for the turn: If a creature has died, the activated ability can be used. For example, you can only activate Skirsdag High Priest’s ability after a creature dies, as awesome as creating 5/5 Demon tokens is.

How Do Triggered Morbid Abilities Work?

Reaper from the Abyss
3

Deathreap Ritual
2

Hollowhenge Scavenger
3


Creature — Demon
Flying
Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, destroy target non-Demon creature.
"Avacyn has deserted you. I welcome your devotion in her stead."
6/6
159/337 M
C14 • EN Matt Stewart
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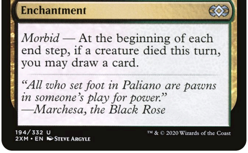
Enchantment
Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, you may draw a card.
"All who set foot in Paliano are pawns in someone's play for power."
—Marchesa, the Black Rose
194/332 U
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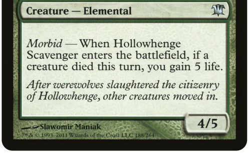
Creature — Elemental
Morbid — When Hollowhenge Scavenger enters the battlefield, if a creature died this turn, you gain 5 life.
After werewolves slaughtered the citizenry of Hollowhenge, other creatures moved in.
Slawomir Maniak
4/5
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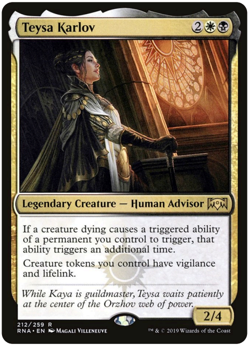
Triggered morbid abilities perform a check to see if a creature died this turn before actually triggering. Reaper from the Abyss reaps a creature at the end step if a creature has died, while Deathreap Ritual draws you a card. Note that these abilities won't trigger at all if a creature hasn't died before the end step begins. Hollowhenge Scavenger has its morbid ability stapled to an ETB trigger.

Does Morbid Work Twice with Commanders Like Teysa Karlov?


Teysa Karlov
2
Legendary Creature — Human Advisor
If a creature dying causes a triggered ability of a permanent you control to trigger, that ability triggers an additional time.
Creature tokens you control have vigilance and lifelink.
While Kaya is guildmaster, Teysa waits patiently at the center of the Orzhov web of power.
2/4
212/259 R
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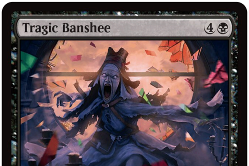
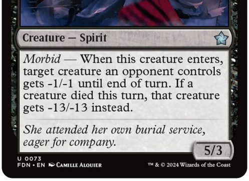
Teysa Karlov **won't double the morbid trigger**. Teysa doubles triggers that happen *when* a creature dies, but morbid is simply a check on *whether a creature has died or not*, and doesn't involve any specific triggers that Teysa can copy.





Creature — Spirit

Morbid — When this creature enters, target creature an opponent controls gets -1/-1 until end of turn. If a creature died this turn, that creature gets -13/-13 instead.

She attended her own burial service, eager for company.

For example, Teysa has no effect on the ETB ability of Tragic Banshee, since that morbid ability does not trigger in response to a creature dying, it simply checks if a creature *has* died.

If My Opponent's Creature Dies Does That Count for Morbid?

Yes, it does. Morbid cares if any creature died that turn, not just yours. If you attack and they chump block, you can follow up with an active morbid spell in the next main phase.

Does Morbid Use the Stack?

It depends. **Only activated and triggered morbid abilities use the stack**. A card like Tragic Slip just resolves and checks if a creature died upon resolution – so it can resolve as a -1/-1 effect or as a -13/-13 effect. Cards like Deathreap Ritual and Reaper from the Abyss have triggered abilities at the beginning of the end step, and these ability triggers go on the stack.

How Does Casualty Work With Morbid?

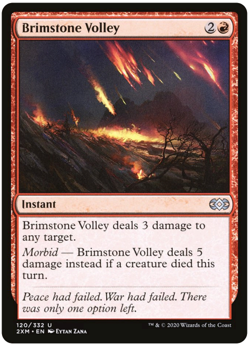
Casualty is a way to sacrifice a creature and copy a spell, so that's a natural way to trigger morbid. Morbid cares whether a creature died, and that'll happen if the casualty cost is paid.

Can Blitz Trigger Morbid?

It's possible for blitz to trigger morbid, but it's not common. There are morbid cards with triggers that are checked at the beginning of the end step, like Deathreap Ritual. Since you sacrifice the blitz creature at the end step, Deathreap Ritual has already checked if a creature died, and thus the morbid trigger won't happen. In a corner case, you can use instant-speed abilities and spells like Tragic Slip or

Skirsdag High Priest's morbid ability after the blitz creature is sacrificed.

Gallery and List of Morbid Cards


Brimstone Volley 2

Instant

Brimstone Volley deals 3 damage to any target.

Morbid — Brimstone Volley deals 5 damage instead if a creature died this turn.

Peace had failed. War had failed. There was only one option left.

120/332 U
2XM • EN Eytan Zana
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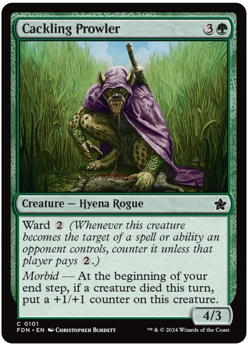
Cackling Prowler 3

Creature — Hyena Rogue

Ward 2 *(Whenever this creature becomes the target of a spell or ability an opponent controls, counter it unless that player pays 2.)*

Morbid — At the beginning of your end step, if a creature died this turn, put a +1/+1 counter on this creature.

4/3

C 0101
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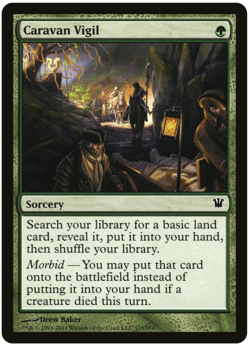
Caravan Vigil

Sorcery

Search your library for a basic land card, reveal it, put it into your hand, then shuffle your library.

Morbid — You may put that card onto the battlefield instead of putting it into your hand if a creature died this turn.

Drew Baker
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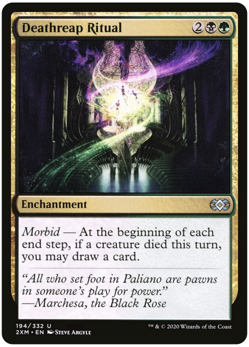
Deathreap Ritual 2

Enchantment

Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, you may draw a card.

"All who set foot in Paliano are pawns in someone's play for power."
—Marchesa, the Black Rose

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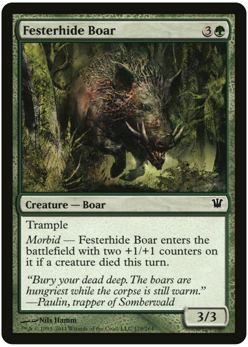
Festerhide Boar 3

Creature — Boar

Trample

Morbid — Festerhide Boar enters the battlefield with two +1/+1 counters on it if a creature died this turn.

"Bury your dead deep. The boars are hungriest while the corpse is still warm."
—Paulin, trapper of Somberwald

3/3

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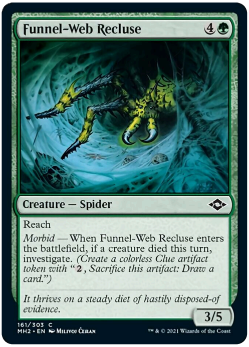
Funnel-Web Recluse 4

Creature — Spider

Reach

Morbid — When Funnel-Web Recluse enters the battlefield, if a creature died this turn, investigate. *(Create a colorless Clue artifact token with "*2*, Sacrifice this artifact: Draw a card.")*

It thrives on a steady diet of hastily disposed-of evidence.

3/5

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MH2 • EN Milivoj Ćeran
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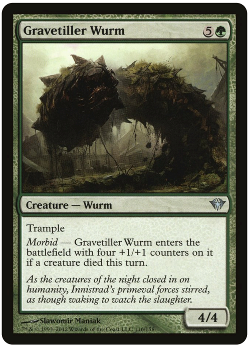
Gravetiller Wurm 5

Creature — Wurm

Trample

Morbid — Gravetiller Wurm enters the battlefield with four +1/+1 counters on it if a creature died this turn.

As the creatures of the night closed in on humanity, Innistrad's primeval forces stirred, as though waking to watch the slaughter.

4/4

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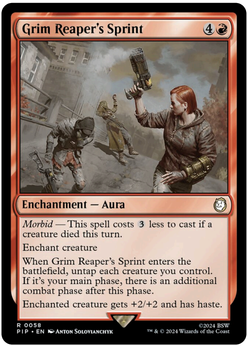
Grim Reaper's Sprint 4

Enchantment — Aura

Morbid — This spell costs 3 less to cast if a creature died this turn.

Enchant creature

When Grim Reaper's Sprint enters the battlefield, untap each creature you control. If it's your main phase, there is an additional combat phase after this phase.

Enchanted creature gets +2/+2 and has haste.

R 0058
PIP • EN Anton Solovianchyk
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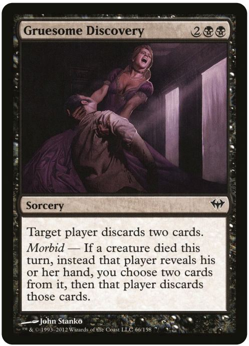
Gruesome Discovery 2

Sorcery

Target player discards two cards.

Morbid — If a creature died this turn, instead that player reveals his or her hand, you choose two cards from it, then that player discards those cards.

John Stanko
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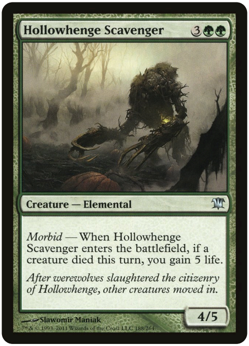

Hollowhenge Scavenger 3

Creature — Elemental

Morbid — When Hollowhenge Scavenger enters the battlefield, if a creature died this turn, you gain 5 life.

After werewolves slaughtered the citizenry of Hollowhenge, other creatures moved in.

4/5

Slawomir Maniak

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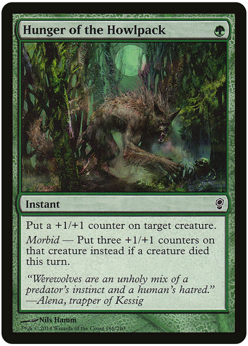

Hunger of the Howlpack

Instant

Put a +1/+1 counter on target creature.

Morbid — Put three +1/+1 counters on that creature instead if a creature died this turn.

"Werewolves are an unholy mix of a predator's instinct and a human's hatred."
—Alena, trapper of Kessig

Nils Hamm

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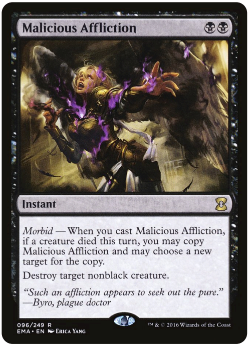

Malicious Affliction

Instant

Morbid — When you cast Malicious Affliction, if a creature died this turn, you may copy Malicious Affliction and may choose a new target for the copy.

Destroy target nonblack creature.

"Such an affliction appears to seek out the pure."
—Byro, plague doctor

096/249 R
EMA • EN Erica Yang

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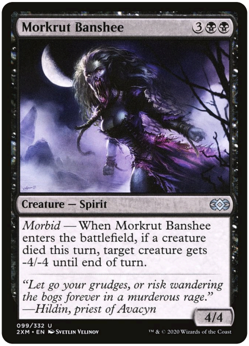

Morkrut Banshee 3

Creature — Spirit

Morbid — When Morkrut Banshee enters the battlefield, if a creature died this turn, target creature gets -4/-4 until end of turn.

"Let go your grudges, or risk wandering the bogs forever in a murderous rage."
—Hildin, priest of Avacyn

4/4

099/332 U
2XM • EN Svetlin Velinov

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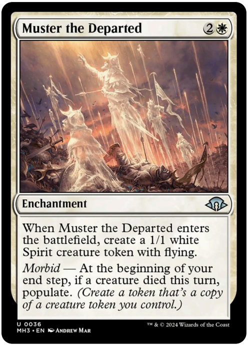

Muster the Departed 2

Enchantment

When Muster the Departed enters the battlefield, create a 1/1 white Spirit creature token with flying.

Morbid — At the beginning of your end step, if a creature died this turn, populate. *(Create a token that's a copy of a creature token you control.)*

U 0036
MH3 • EN Andrew Mar

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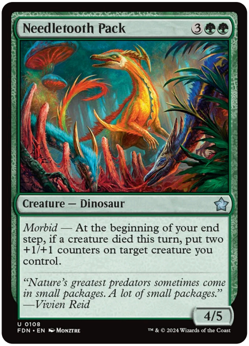

Needletooth Pack 3

Creature — Dinosaur

Morbid — At the beginning of your end step, if a creature died this turn, put two +1/+1 counters on target creature you control.

"Nature's greatest predators sometimes come in small packages. A lot of small packages."
—Vivien Reid

4/5

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FDN • EN Monztre

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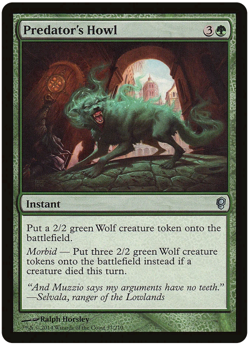

Predator's Howl 3

Instant

Put a 2/2 green Wolf creature token onto the battlefield.

Morbid — Put three 2/2 green Wolf creature tokens onto the battlefield instead if a creature died this turn.

"And Muzzio says my arguments have no teeth."
—Selvala, ranger of the Lowlands

Ralph Horsley

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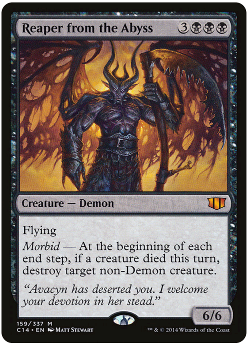

Reaper from the Abyss 3

Creature — Demon

Flying

Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, destroy target non-Demon creature.

"Avacyn has deserted you. I welcome your devotion in her stead."

6/6

159/337 M
C14 • EN Matt Stewart

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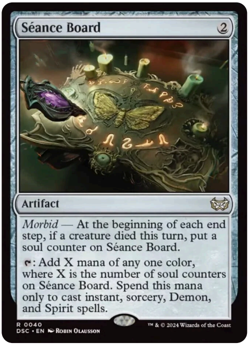

Séance Board 2

Artifact

Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, put a soul counter on Séance Board.

↷: Add X mana of any one color, where X is the number of soul counters on Séance Board. Spend this mana only to cast instant, sorcery, Demon, and Spirit spells.

R 0040
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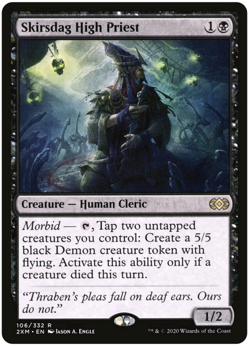

Skirsdag High Priest 1

Creature — Human Cleric

Morbid — ⟳, Tap two untapped creatures you control: Create a 5/5 black Demon creature token with flying. Activate this ability only if a creature died this turn.

"Thraben's pleas fall on deaf ears. Ours do not."

1/2

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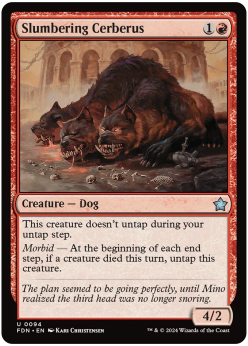

Slumbering Cerberus 1

Creature — Dog

This creature doesn't untap during your untap step.

Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, untap this creature.

The plan seemed to be going perfectly, until Mino realized the third head was no longer snoring.

4/2

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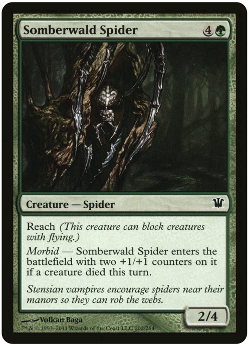

Somberwald Spider 4

Creature — Spider

Reach *(This creature can block creatures with flying.)*

Morbid — Somberwald Spider enters the battlefield with two +1/+1 counters on it if a creature died this turn.

Stensian vampires encourage spiders near their manors so they can rob the webs.

2/4

Volkan Baga
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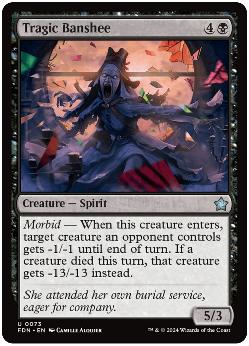

Tragic Banshee 4

Creature — Spirit

Morbid — When this creature enters, target creature an opponent controls gets -1/-1 until end of turn. If a creature died this turn, that creature gets -13/-13 instead.

She attended her own burial service, eager for company.

5/3

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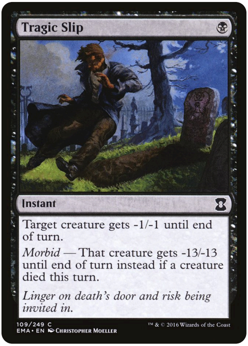

Tragic Slip

Instant

Target creature gets -1/-1 until end of turn.

Morbid — That creature gets -13/-13 until end of turn instead if a creature died this turn.

Linger on death's door and risk being invited in.

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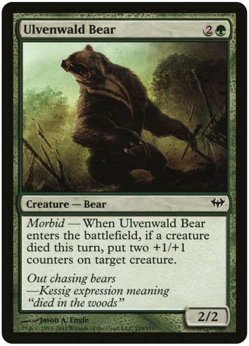

Ulvenwald Bear 2

Creature — Bear

Morbid — When Ulvenwald Bear enters the battlefield, if a creature died this turn, put two +1/+1 counters on target creature.

Out chasing bears
—Kessig expression meaning "died in the woods"

2/2

Jason A. Engle
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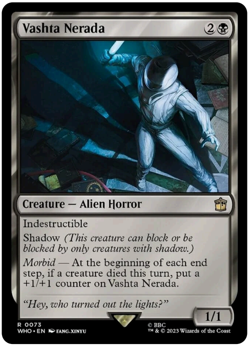

Vashta Nerada 2

Creature — Alien Horror

Indestructible

Shadow *(This creature can block or be blocked by only creatures with shadow.)*

Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, put a +1/+1 counter on Vashta Nerada.

"Hey, who turned out the lights?"

1/1

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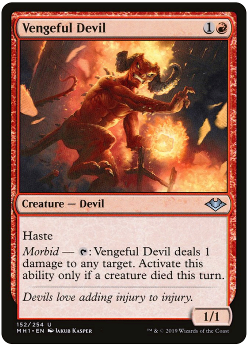

Vengeful Devil 1

Creature — Devil

Haste

Morbid — ⟳: Vengeful Devil deals 1 damage to any target. Activate this ability only if a creature died this turn.

Devils love adding injury to injury.

1/1

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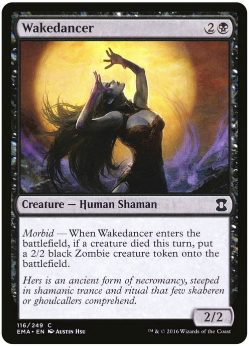

Wakedancer 2

Creature — Human Shaman

Morbid — When Wakedancer enters the battlefield, if a creature died this turn, put a 2/2 black Zombie creature token onto the battlefield.

Hers is an ancient form of necromancy, steeped in shamanic trance and ritual that few skaberen or ghoulcallers comprehend.

2/2

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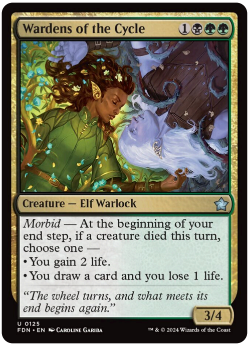

Wardens of the Cycle 1

Creature — Elf Warlock

Morbid — At the beginning of your end step, if a creature died this turn, choose one —

- You gain 2 life.
- You draw a card and you lose 1 life.

"The wheel turns, and what meets its end begins again."

3/4

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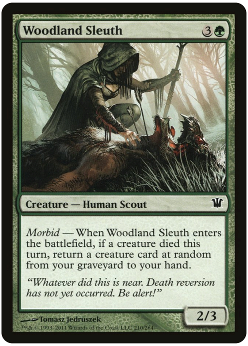

Woodland Sleuth 3

Creature — Human Scout

Morbid — When Woodland Sleuth enters the battlefield, if a creature died this turn, return a creature card at random from your graveyard to your hand.

"Whatever did this is near. Death reversion has not yet occurred. Be alert!"

2/3

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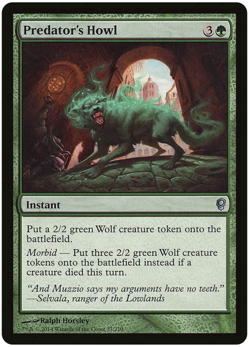
- Brimstone Volley
- Cackling Prowler
- Caravan Vigil
- Deathreap Ritual
- Festerhide Boar
- Funnel-Web Recluse
- Gravetiller Wurm
- Grim Reaper's Sprint
- Gruesome Discovery
- Hollowhenge Scavenger
- Hunger of the Howlpack
- Malicious Affliction
- Morkrut Banshee
- Muster the Departed
- Needletooth Pack
- Predator's Howl
- Reaper from the Abyss
- Séance Board
- Skirsdag High Priest

- Slumbering Cerberus
- Somberwald Spider
- Tragic Banshee
- Tragic Slip
- Ulvenwald Bear
- Vashta Nerada
- Vengeful Devil
- Wakedancer
- Wardens of the Cycle
- Woodland Sleuth
- Wrinkly Monkey Shenanigans

Best Morbid Cards

#8. Predator's Howl



Predator's Howl

Instant

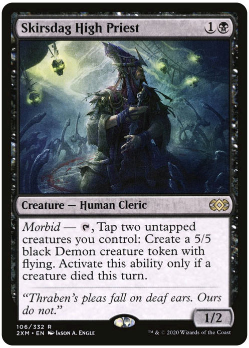
Put a 2/2 green Wolf creature token onto the battlefield.

Morbid — Put three 2/2 green Wolf creature tokens onto the battlefield instead if a creature died this turn.

"And Muzzio says my arguments have no teeth."
—Selvala, ranger of the Lowlands

Like Tragic Slip, the difference between paying 4 mana for a token and three tokens is huge. Play Predator's Howl if you can reliably trigger morbid.

#7. Skirsdag High Priest



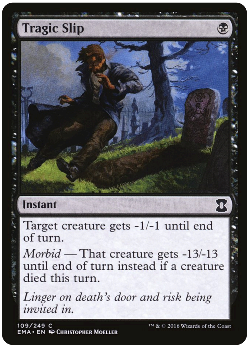
Morbid — ↷, Tap two untapped creatures you control: Create a 5/5 black Demon creature token with flying. Activate this ability only if a creature died this turn.

"Thraben's pleas fall on deaf ears. Ours do not."

Skirsdag High Priest's ability is awesome, but you have to jump through extra hoops to activate it. It's probably best used in EDH, where you can have a black-based deck or commander that already produces tokens.

Sacrificing a creature and using Skirsdag High Priest at the end of turn to make a free 5/5 flier is very nice.

#6. Tragic Slip



Target creature gets -1/-1 until end of turn.

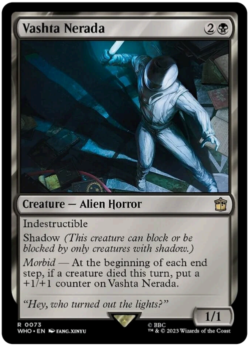
Morbid — That creature gets -13/-13 until end of turn instead if a creature died this turn.

Linger on death's door and risk being invited in.

The gap between -1/-1 and -13/-13 is huge, so morbid plays a huge part in Tragic Slip's effectiveness. Definitely play this if you're playing EDH sacrifice-based decks since it gets around indestructible.

There was a time when Tragic Slip was played in Modern before Fatal Push was printed. It thrived on the abundance of X/1s like Noble Hierarch, Birds of Paradise, and Dark Confidant in the meta.

#5. Vashta Nerada



Vashta Nerada 2

Creature — Alien Horror

Indestructible

Shadow *(This creature can block or be blocked by only creatures with shadow.)*

Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, put a +1/+1 counter on Vashta Nerada.

"Hey, who turned out the lights?"

1/1

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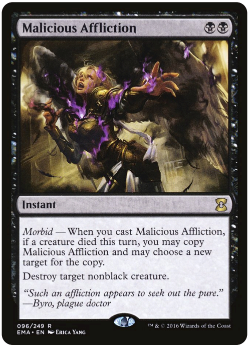
Vashta Nerada starts small as a mere 1/1 for 3 mana. However, it has shadow and indestructible, and it can get a +1/+1 counter on each end step. It's a creature you can let stay on the battlefield: Creatures will die around it naturally while Vashta slowly feeds on those deaths.

#4. Malicious Affliction



Malicious Affliction

Instant

Morbid — When you cast Malicious Affliction, if a creature died this turn, you may copy Malicious Affliction and may choose a new target for the copy.

Destroy target nonblack creature.

"Such an affliction appears to seek out the pure."
—Byro, plague doctor

096/249 R
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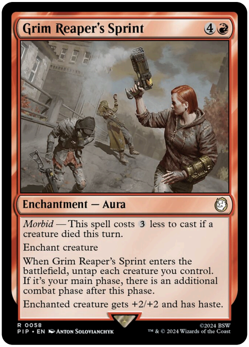
Malicious Affliction is a Doom Blade that can be two with extra steps. It's just a regular Doom Blade without morbid, but it's a two-for-one with it.

#3. Grim Reaper's Sprint



Morbid — This spell costs 3 less to cast if a creature died this turn.

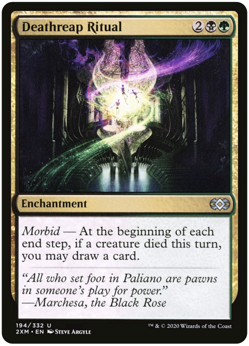
Enchant creature

When Grim Reaper's Sprint enters the battlefield, untap each creature you control. If it's your main phase, there is an additional combat phase after this phase.

Enchanted creature gets +2/+2 and has haste.

Grim Reaper's Sprint is an aura that can grant you an extra combat phase. It usually costs 5, but if you can trigger morbid, it's a steal at 2 mana. It also represents a lot of damage, as you're adding +2/+2 and haste to a creature, besides the extra combat step.

#2. Deathreap Ritual

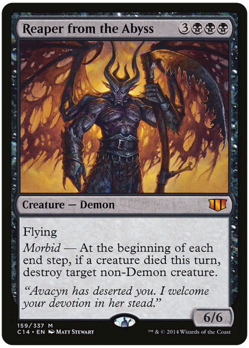


Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, you may draw a card.

"All who set foot in Paliano are pawns in someone's play for power."
—Marchesa, the Black Rose

Deathreap Ritual gives you an extra card every turn in sacrifice-based Golgari decks. It works if you kill the opponent's creatures using your removal spells, or with edict effects.

#1. Reaper from the Abyss



Reaper from the Abyss

Creature — Demon

Flying

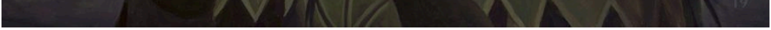
Morbid — At the beginning of each end step, if a creature died this turn, destroy target non-Demon creature.

"Avacyn has deserted you. I welcome your devotion in her stead."

Reaper from the Abyss is one of the few demons without any downside or life payment effects. Its morbid ability is just an added benefit. If you attack with it and it's blocked, you'll destroy an extra creature.

This has nice implications in EDH because it triggers morbid on each end step, though you *must* target something, which can backfire if you're the only player left with non-demon creatures in play.

Decklist: Dina Morbid in Commander



Dina, Soul Steeper (*Strixhaven: School of Mages*) | *Illustration by Chris Rahn*

Commander (1)

Dina, Soul Steeper

Creatures (33)

Deathgreeter
Essence Warden
Viscera Seer
Blood Artist
Nether Traitor
Prosperous Innkeeper
Sakura-Tribe Elder
Zulaport Cutthroat
Chatterfang, Squirrel General
Dross Harvester
Liliana's Standard Bearer
Marauding Blight-Priest
Midnight Reaper
Morbid Opportunist
Nadier's Nightblade
Ophiomancer
Pawn of Ulamog
Scute Swarm
Sedgemoor Witch
Veinwitch Coven
Meren of Clan Nel Toth
Pitiless Plunderer
Prowling Geistcatcher
Smothering Abomination
Mitotic Slime
Phyrexian Delver
Tendershoot Dryad
Protean Hulk
Haywire Mite
Drivnod, Carnage Dominus

Instants (11)

Tragic Slip
Village Rites
Golgari Charm
Infernal Grasp
Plumb the Forbidden
Beast Within
Chord of Calling
Baleful Mastery
Lethal Scheme
Mortality Spear
Culling the Weak

Sorceries (9)

Bone Shards
Eaten Alive
Pest Infestation
Bala Ged Recovery
Cultivate
Kodama's Reach
Primal Growth
Victimize
Dark Prophecy
Fecundity
Pattern of Rebirth
Moldervine Reclamation

Artifacts (6)

Skullclamp
Sol Ring
Lightning Greaves
Ashnod's Altar
Phyrexian Altar
Bolas's Citadel

Lands (34)

Blooming Marsh
Castle Garenbrig
Command Tower
Deathcap Glade
Fabled Passage
Forest x8
Jungle Hollow
Khalni Garden
Llanowar Wastes
Necroblossom Snarl
Overgrown Tomb
Phyrexian Tower
Riveteers Overlook
Swamp x8
Tainted Wood
Temple of Malady

Vindictive Vampire
Yawgmoth, Thran Physician
Death Tyrant

Skyshroud Claim

Enchantments (6)

Bastion of Remembrance
Blight Mound

Temple of the False God
Undergrowth Stadium
Woodland Cemetery
Woodland Chasm

Dina is a commander that's also a sacrifice outlet. A Dina, Soul Steeper deck usually revolves around gaining life and using the lifegain to damage opponents. You can take advantage of Dina's cheap sacrifice outlet to include a few morbid cards, and there's a few in this list. Other useful cards have morbid-like abilities, like Morbid Opportunist, or care about death triggers.

The deck is a bunch of sacrifice outlets, cards that make tokens/disposable creatures, and cards that care about other creatures dying. You also want cards like Mitotic Slime where you get a huge benefit when they die. Here are just a few examples:

Sacrifice Outlets

- Dina, Soul Steeper
- Viscera Seer
- Skullclamp
- Village Rites

Tokens Generators

- Ophiomancer
- Pawn of Ulamog
- Sedgemoor Witch
- Tendershoot Dryad

Cards That Care About Creatures Dying

- Tragic Slip
- Moldervine Reclamation
- Morbid Opportunist
- Deathgreeter
- Blood Artist

- Meren of Clan Nel Toth

Wrap Up

Brimstone Volley | Illustration by Eytan Zana

Caring about creatures dying is a fun way to convey horror in gameplay and keep opponents and players guessing. The sentence “if a creature died this turn” is easy to include in a lot of designs, radically changing the effect.

Morbid is bound to return since WotC deals with keywords in a different way now, if only something in the vein of Morbid Opportunist and Ghoulish Procession. The rules are different in Commander, Masters, or Horizons sets, where they’re more inclined to use keywords on a card or two.

What are your experiences with morbid? Do you think it’s a fun or lame mechanic? Let me know in the comments below or in the Draftsim Discord.

Stay safe, and thanks for reading!